DAKSHAYANI VELAYUDHAN

1912–1978



An unusual family

Dakshayani Velayudhan was born into a Dalit family in present-day Kerala. At the time, social rules dictated every aspect of the lives of so-called lower-caste individuals, from the kind of clothes they could wear, to where they could live, and how they could earn a living. They were also frequently denied access to education. But Velayudhan was born to progressive parents in a region that had a history of strong anti-caste movements. Her own family had resisted discrimination from those higher up in the caste hierarchy. With their support, she became the first scheduled-caste woman to receive a bachelor's degree.

"THE WORKING OF THE CONSTITUTION WILL DEPEND UPON HOW THE PEOPLE WILL CONDUCT THEMSELVES IN THE FUTURE, NOT ON THE ACTUAL EXECUTION OF THE LAW. SO I HOPE THAT IN